How to Pitch Well

Content & Design

THE CORE IDEA

“Nobody invests in what they don’t understand.”

Understand → Remember → Get interested

THE MOST COMMON MISTAKE

Trying to sound

~~impressive~~

instead of

clear.

01 Content

The 7 questions

Source: Michael Seibel, “How to pitch your company” — Y Combinator

THE FRAMEWORK

A good pitch answers 7 questions

01 What do you do?

02 How big is the market?

03 What's your progress?

04 What's your unique insight?

05 How do you make money?

06 Who's on your team?

07 What do you want?

Answer each one briefly and you're already ahead of most teams.

What do you do?

Name + what it does.
In one sentence.

EXAMPLE · SOCIALCAM

“Socialcam is a mobile app that makes it easy to take videos and share them with friends and family.”

Goal: make them want to ask the next question.

TRICK · EXAMPLE: GOOGLE

Walk through the user path

✕ ABSTRACT

“We organize the world’s information.”

✓ CONCRETE

“You type a question into a box and we show you pages that answer it.”

QUESTION 2 OF 7

How big is the market?

Calculate bottom-up.

Real customers × Price = Market

BELLABEAT Women aged 14–45 in the US × one tracker every two years ~~"all women"~~

QUESTION 3 OF 7

What’s your progress?

Progress

Time

IN THIS COURSE, PROGRESS MEANS

- Interviews done
- Users trying the MVP
- Hypotheses validated or discarded
- Landing page data

QUESTION 4 OF 7

What’s your unique insight?

What do you know about the problem that others don’t?

GMAIL, 2004

1 GB

Email is a personal archive — so why force people to delete?

Enough storage to never delete again.

Passion ≠ *argument*

A weak insight said with energy looks worse, not better.

What convinces: **evidence from your interviews.**

QUESTION 5 OF 7

How do you make money?

One model. The obvious one. No shame.

Michael Seibel on Justin.tv: embarrassed to say “advertising”, he pitched a mix of models.

Justin.tv	Justin.tv	Justin.tv	Justin.tv	The obvious answer
~~Virtual goods~~	~~Product placement~~	~~Chat ads~~	~~Contests~~	**Advertising**

QUESTION 6 OF 7

Who’s on your team?

Can this team execute? Not GPAs, not internships.



How many



Who builds



How long together



Commitment

QUESTION 7 OF 7

What do you want?

Ask for something specific.

ASK FOR

- Investment
- A pilot
- Contacts
- Users to test with

NOT

~~*"What do you think?"*~~

~~*"Is this a good idea?"*~~

No jargon.
No acronyms.
No *“platform.”*

If it sounds too simple, it’s probably right.

THE EMAIL TEST

Two sentences, in writing

2

sentences

What your product does

→

1

smart friend

Who doesn't know the project

→

0

questions back

They explain it in their own words. If not, rewrite.

02 Design

Legible, simple, obvious

Source: Kevin Hale, “How to design a better pitch deck” — Y Combinator

THE THREE RULES

01

Legible.

Readable from the back row

02

Simple.

One slide, one idea

03

Obvious.

Clear at a glance

RULE 01 · LEGIBLE

Readable from the back row

- Large type
- Bold
- Simple font
- High contrast
- Text at the top

Row 12 ✓

Row 12 ✓

Row 12 ✗

Row 12 ✗

One slide = one idea.

sim·plex

One fold. Not braided with others.

com·plex

Braided together. Two ideas, one slide.

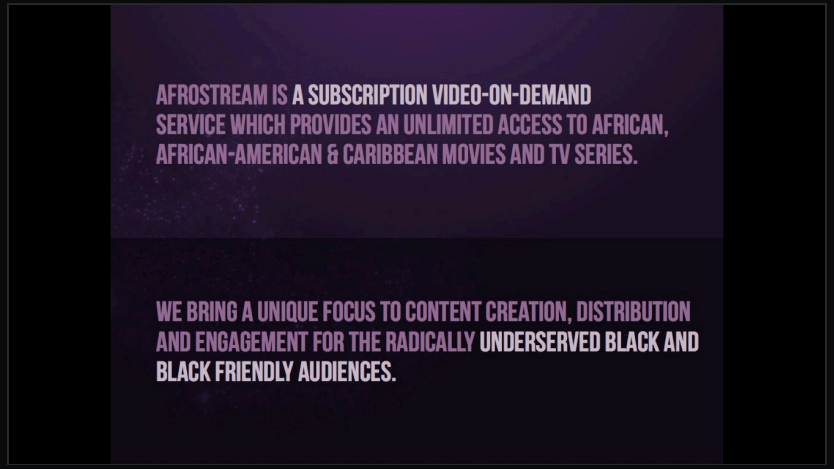
5–7 ideas

You don’t need 25 slides.

EXAMPLE · AFROSTREAM

From two ideas to one

EARLY VERSION



Two ideas, every nuance — nobody remembers it.

DEMO DAY



“Netflix of African and African American content.”

RULE 03 · OBVIOUS

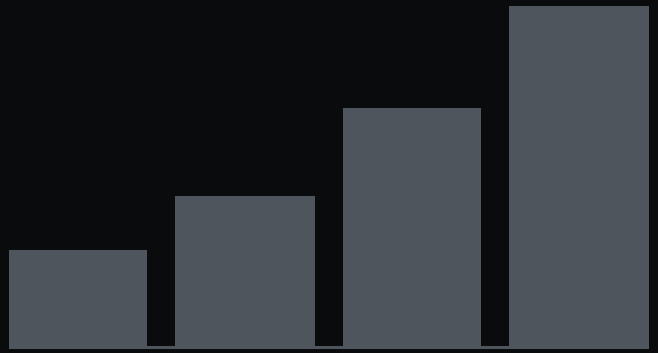
“If it isn’t clear at a glance, it doesn’t work.”

THE GLANCE TEST Show the slide → Ask what it means → They say your idea immediately

CHARTS

Write the conclusion

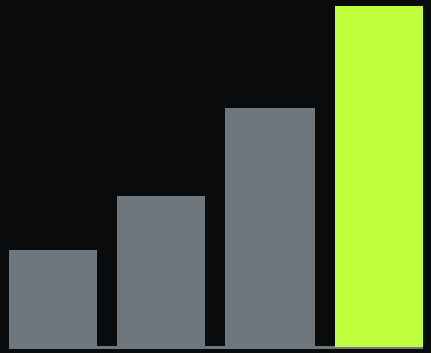
UNTITLED



The jury has to interpret it.

WITH THE CONCLUSION

Landing conversion: 2% → 7% in 3 weeks



They barely need to look at the chart.

EVERY ELEMENT COSTS TIME

What to cut

Exception: a crowded slide that shows an overwhelming problem — on purpose.

- ~~Too much text~~
- ~~Caveats~~
- ~~Logos on every slide~~
- ~~Untitled photos~~
- ~~Animations~~
- ~~Memes, inside jokes~~

EXAMPLE · MAGIC

Crowded on purpose

THE PROBLEM



Thousands of services, one account each.

THE ANSWER

One interface to **thousands of services.**

“One interface to thousands of services.”

PRODUCT ON SLIDES

Screenshots: almost never

Small text, many functions, slow to read. Show the flow instead — SparkGift:

Step 1

Choose amount

→

Step 2

Choose stock

→

Step 3

Send



A whole product in two lines

Medical cannabis delivery, explained without a single screenshot.

Better than any mix of buttons, links and interface chrome.

THE JURY INVESTS IN YOU

“Investors invest in teams, not slides.”

If the jury is reading, they’re not listening.

03 The course

Applying it to your pitch

SECOND DELIVERY

25 November

What the jury will look for

- ✓ What you do, in one sentence
- ✓ Evidence, not opinions
- ✓ Landing and MVP metrics
- ✓ What you learned and what you changed
- ✓ A concrete next step
- ✓ A clear ask

HOMEWORK

Run the email test. Bring your sentence rewritten.